

Setting things up

When you first launched GNOME, the only thing you might have really noticed was that dark bar across the top. On the right hand side, there is a bunch of icons. Click on any of them and you'll see a drop down menu. It'll show you the audio volume, your network connections (eg WiFi or Ethernet). It shows you your username and finally, three icons (Settings, Lock Screen and Power Off/Restart). Other items will appear here depending upon your computer and settings, but these are the basics. Much of the items in this menu will be self explanatory, but if you aren't already on WiFi or plugged into the network, you are going to want to do this. Click on the WiFi icon and a drop-down list offers you to select your WiFi base station from a list, as well as selecting other more advanced WiFi settings.

Many of these menus lead you to the gnome settings dialogue. This is always accessible by clicking on the icon with the spanner & screwdriver. When you click this you can change most of the pertinent settings relating to your computer, from your background wallpaper, to power management settings. This is analogous to the Control Panel in Microsoft Windows, or System Preferences for a Mac.

Much of the items on the settings dialogue should be fairly self explanatory, so for the interests of brevity I'll explain the more in-depth items only. The look and feel of the settings dialogue differs between distributions (and versions), however most of the actions available perform the same functions.

Notifications

Notifications are the pop-up messages that appear at the top of the screen when a particular App wants to make you aware of something. Just in the way that your mobile phone shows you an alert when someone sends you a message, for example. When apps are installed, they automatically get added to this list (if they are apps that use notifications). You can choose to disable notifications on an app-by-app basis, or switch off notifications entirely (Notification Banners – toggle to OFF). By default, notifications can be seen even when your screen is locked, so for example, you can see if you have a calendar appointment coming. You can switch this behaviour off too.

When you click on a particular app in the list, you can enable and disable specific notification items depending upon the context of the notifications the app makes. For example, an app may make sound alerts as well as pop-up banners. You may wish to add privacy by not showing the message content in the banner; this setting is the default. This may be useful to switch on for emails for example, so you can see whether an email is important to you or not, simply by seeing a preview of it in the notification banner. This saves you time having to switch back and forth to Evolution for email.

Online Accounts

This item is where your digital life becomes one. It combines all of the most common online services in one easy dialogue, so you'll want to set this up before long. When you enter this setting, it'll be empty apart from a button saying 'Add an online account'. If you want to add more than one account (or remove one), note the + and – icons to the bottom left.

At the time of writing, you can add 10 different accounts. These are: Google, Facebook, Flickr, Microsoft Live, ownCloud, Pocket, Foursquare, Microsoft Exchange (calendar/email etc), Media Server and Other Accounts (such as standard IMAP/POP3 Email and AIM chat). Click on any of these to set them up.

Tux tip: Your connections to cloud accounts like Google and Facebook may disconnect and you will have to re-authenticate periodically. This is to keep your accounts safe.

If you want to connect to your Google account for example, Click on the Google icon. It will ask you to enter your email address associated with your Google account, followed by its password. It will then ask you to give the GNOME desktop permissions to use Google's features. Scroll to the bottom of that list of permissions and press 'Allow'. You'll now be presented with a list of toggle items which you can use your Google account within GNOME for. For example, Email, Calendar, Contacts, Chat, Files, Printers and Photos. Note that if you select them, they will automatically be downloaded to your computer.

Tux tip: At the time of writing Files are not synchronised like they are with Google Drive on Windows or Mac. Rather you can upload and download files from your Google drive via the Files app. If you'd like to know how to use Google Files fully, [check out this tutorial](#). It also shows 'full synchronisation' alternatives.

Network

In this settings dialogue you get to change the settings for your Network. This includes your Ethernet and WiFi adapter(s), set up a proxy, add a VPN, configure a VLAN and bond, team or bridge a network interface. If you want to change settings for any of the configured networks, click on the cog icon to the bottom-right.

Backups

By default, system backups are switched off. This option unlocks a very powerful, yet simple to use backup feature which works in a similar way to the 'Time Machine' app in macOS. You can schedule when your backup runs (eg, weekly, daily etc), whether each backup is kept indefinitely or not, which folders to ignore and where to store the backups.

By default, the backups are stored in your home folder on the local disk. You'll want to change this, so Select one of the alternative storage locations from the drop-down list. These can be Amazon S3, Google Cloud, Rackspace Cloud or generic FTP/SSH/WebDav/Windows Share based locations.